

Brokered Global Engagement Through Patronal Repurposing. Evolution and Structure of Russia's Adaptation Networks

Sebastian Hoppe* Anna Filippova[†] Aram Bagdasarian[‡]

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Abstract

Trade fragmentation and geopolitical conflict have enhanced the role of intermediaries in the world economy. We theorize *adaptation brokerage networks* as a mechanism through which authoritarian regimes repurpose existing organizations anchored by strategically embedded elite brokers, who serve as institutionalized patrons, to sustain international engagement under external constraints. Using Russia as a critical case, we draw on an original dataset of over 40,000 Russian-language media articles to extract more than 900 individual and collective actors substantially engaging with Kirill Dmitriev, head of the Russian Direct Investment Fund (RDIF), from 2010 to 2025. Through time-sliced co-occurrence network analysis, we trace Dmitriev's context-dependent evolution as an institutionalized patronal broker along the RDIF's organizational flexibility: from an investment-attracting sovereign wealth fund to a sanction-proofing platform, to a pandemic-era health politics tool, and ultimately to a wartime backchannel for opportunistic diplomatic rehabilitation amidst war and global energy crises. While international partnerships shifted substantially, the RDIF's structural core function as a patron-mediated and repurposable interface between Russia's political economy and the global system remained structurally intact. The findings contribute to debates on the spatial politics of global economic adaptation, authoritarian flexibility, and the infrastructural logics of sanction circumvention.

Keywords: global political economy, adaptation, networks, brokerage, Russia

*Centre for East European and International Studies (ZOiS), Berlin

[†]Centre for East European and International Studies (ZOiS), Berlin

[‡]Harvard University, Boston, MA

1 Introduction

In a world of geopolitical conflict and fragmenting trade relationships, brokers - webs of actors linking two or more hitherto unconnected social, economic or political spaces - have become critical for both states and societies adapting to macro-structural change. Unlike classical Liberal and Marxist theories of globalization, which for long assumed or criticized, respectively, the global emergence of a unified transnational capitalist space, the presence shows that intermediating networks flourish precisely because today's order is spatially uneven and characterised by multilayered, incoherent, and contradictory reconfigurations in global diplomatic, political and economic processes. order is composed of politically clashing yet economically interdependent blocs of states, overlapping yet porous sanctions regimes, rival and contested climate standards, and variegated (non-)growth regimes, all of which pull in different directions, eliciting highly uneven national trajectories of political-economic adaptation. In this unpredictable global environment, maintaining or gaining access to resources, knowledge and institutions via brokers allows state elites, companies and societal groups to reduce insecurity and organize modifications to their own strategies of social and economic reproduction. Therefore, brokerage lies at the core of individuals', groups', and states' adaptive capacity in contemporary global restructuring.

At least since 2014, the Russian Federation constitutes a critical case in debates about the adaptive capacity of authoritarian regimes. A growing body of anecdotal evidence and investigative reporting documents the critical role of enabling intermediary webs for the stability of the Russian state and economy in light of geoeconomic conflict, Western sanctions, and war: logistics firms specialised in trade re-routing, diplomats in Riyadh, Ankara and Washington, sanction busters in EU member states, lawyers in Cyprus and London, bankers in Hong Kong and New York, and an ilk of globally dispersed ideological admirers of the Kremlin's cause, all of which stitch together Russia's surprisingly enduring global engagement (Götz and MacFarlane, 2022; Melville, Akhremenko, and Mironyuk, 2019). Yet despite these rich investigations, a systematic account of how the intermediate actors at the service of

Russian statecraft operate structurally, how their networks evolve over time, and who are the critical organisers on the Russian side is still lacking.

To provide such an account, this paper utilizes Social Network Analysis (SNA) and introduces the concept of *adaptation brokerage networks (ABNs)* – cross-border webs of individuals, firms, organisations and institutions that mediate between a state’s idiosyncratic domestic order and a changing and increasingly fragmented global political economy. Understanding this networked layer of intermediaries seems not only critical for understanding Russia’s economic nationalism, detecting sanction evasion schemes, and identifying the supply chains feeding its current war against Ukraine, but more broadly regarding how states and societies relate to global restructuring in the 21st century (Helleiner, 2024): the fracturing of economic interdependence, the multipolar and increasingly war-torn splintering of diplomatic conduct, decarbonization as a physiologically necessary yet politically contested imperative, and calls for on-shoring production and unmediated access to natural resources amidst heightened geopolitics.

Russia under Vladimir Putin provides a well-placed laboratory for the study of networked adaptation and the role of brokerage. On the one hand, it is a critical and information-rich case of personalist and networked authoritarian politics (Ledeneva, 2013), which is well-covered by daily media publications and investigative reporting as well as area-focused scholarship. Moreover, since at least the Global Financial Crisis in 2008 (GFC), the Russian state has faced immense external pressure to adapt its extractivist political economy (Gaddy and Ickes, 2010). Since 2014, furthermore, Moscow has faced ever tighter Western sanctions while simultaneously deepening ties with non-Western actors. In fact, Russian attempts at import substitution and industrial policy can be traced back even before its fallout with Ukraine, starting in the winter of 2011/12 with Putin’s orchestrated return to the presidential office. In attempting to reinvigorate Russian industry and diversify trade partners, Putin has not only pursued a more conservative and ideologically grounded turn in domestic and economic policy-making, including a much more confrontational stance vis-à-

vis the West (Bluhm, 2023). The Russian state elite and its bureaucracy were also adapting to global macro-processes – changes in the global financial architecture after the GFC, the consolidation of sanctions as a tool of statecraft in the wake of Western policies vis-a-vis Iran, Libya and Syria, long-term decarbonization, and the emergence of new multipolar diplomatic networks. These macro-processes represent both profound challenges and new opportunities for Russia’s political economy that go beyond the Kremlin’s short-term management of the consequences of its war campaign to subjugate Ukraine.

On the other hand, however, despite its centrality in the study of authoritarianism, global resource politics, and sanctions, the Russian case remains underexplored in important empirical, theoretical and methodological aspects. Empirically, there are almost no network studies on the role of *border-crossing* webs linking Russia to different realms of the global order¹. Theoretically, the study of networks in Russia hardly ever discusses the repercussions of network dynamics against the context of Russia’s broader political-economic trajectory and global integration. In fact, this gap surpasses Russian politics: despite surging scholarly interest in state-led modes of adaptation, resilience and capacity-building, there has been a conceptual neglect of the uneven individual, institutional and corporate networks, strategies and resource exchanges facilitating adaptation on behalf of state elites, corporate actors and social constituencies (an exclusion being Graaff, 2012).

The article addresses this gap by making a twofold contribution. First, it offers a novel conceptual framework that integrates the empirical analysis of networks and brokers with the study of state-led adaptation in the global political economy, utilizing a mixed-methods strategy that pairs SNA with qualitative case study research, to reconstruct the evolution and structure of authoritarian ABNs over time. Second, we provide evidence of Russia’s ABN in late Putinism, tracing how its topology re-configured before and after Russia’s annexation of Crimea (2014), during the global COVID-19 crisis (2020-21), and after the full-scale invasion of Ukraine (2022). For this analysis, we construct a network around Kirill Dmitriev,

1. A notable exception, if non-formalized and explorative, includes Marten, 2013

since 2011 CEO of the Russian Direct Investment Fund (RDIF) and, since 2025, Special Presidential Envoy on Foreign Investment and Economic Cooperation. We treat Dmitriev and his extended network as a window into and exemplary case of Russian ABNs. Like few others, Dmitriev’s career illustrates the repertoire of modern brokerage. He was socialized and educated in both Russia and Western top-tier universities, and pursued an international business career without losing touch to the heights of Russian state power. Later, he facilitated co-investments with Blackstone and Goldman Sachs, among others, created joint funds with Abu Dhabi’s Mubadala and Saudi Arabia’s Public Investment Fund (PIF) despite sanctions, was deeply engaged in Russia’s vaccine diplomacy with sovereign lenders during the COVID-19 pandemic, and, most recently, has even attempted an Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) rebranding of Russian projects to court new pools of “green” capital. His extended, border-crossing networks, the domestic and international institutions he has engaged with, the international deals he has helped facilitate and, not least, him being close to Putin, thus offer a theoretically and empirically fruitful test case for the ABN concept.²

The paper’s findings suggest that organizations such as the RDIF can be repurposed for the most different political "missions" set by the state, if these organizations are managed by institutionalized "sub-patronal" brokers who are, on the one hand, deeply embedded in the state elite and obedient to upper patrons in the socio-institutional hierarchy and, on the other hand, have sufficient resources and authority themselves to manage their own client base within and outside the organization they oversee.³ We argue that Russia’s resilient global engagement in light of geopolitical conflict, sanctions and the exhaustion of extractivism draws significantly on this highly adaptive class of intermediaries who reroute resources and re-legitimize Russian state power in a flexible and opportunistic way. Our evidence shows

2. The broker activities of liminal actors operating between Western countries and the Soviet Union and post-Soviet Russia, respectively, have been noted by others as well (Lambroschini, 2024; Shaw and Iordachi, 2023)

3. A patron can be defined as a node of allocative and coercive capacity in a personalised network, whose authority derives from the ability to selectively dispense material benefits and sanctions to a set of clients bound by relations of dependence and actual acquaintance (Hale, 2015, pp. 9–10). Patrons become sub-patrons once they serve as client to an upper patron and, therefore, integrate into a larger patron-client network.

how Dmitriev’s domestic and international networks evolved throughout several crises and contingent missions assigned "from above", continuously changing the RDIF’s organizational purpose: from an investment-attracting sovereign wealth fund to a sanction-proofing platform, to a pandemic-era health politics tool, and ultimately to a wartime backchannel for opportunistic diplomatic rehabilitation amidst war and global energy crises. However, while international partnerships shifted geographically, substantially, and compositionally, the RDIF’s structural core function as a patron-mediated and repurposable interface between Russia’s political economy and the global system remained structurally intact. This suggests that sanctions, war and diplomatic isolation may have altered Russia’s macroeconomic trajectory and the availability of financial resources, but have not penetrated deeply enough to destabilise the sociological network mechanisms steering personalist regime adaptability.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 locates the ABN concept within network and political economy scholarship, specifies theoretical core propositions, and details the methodology and data sources of the study. Section 3 maps Dmitriev’s RDIF network, describing both its cross-temporal structural architecture as well as its evolution and adaptive reconfigurations after major geopolitical shocks and crisis. Section 4 concludes by explicating the paper’s contribution to the literature and flagging fruitful follow-up avenues for investigation.

2 Adaptation Brokerage Networks

Our study builds on long-standing strands of network and political economy scholarship (Hafner-Burton, Kahler, and Montgomery, 2009; Hafner-Burton and Montgomery, 2009; Oatley et al., 2013; Busch and Juska, 1997; Emmert-Streib et al., 2018; Kobrin, 1997; van Apeldoorn and Graaff, 2016; Graaff, 2011), particularly studies singling out brokerage as one of the key mechanisms steering network dynamics (Goddard, 2009; Halevy, Halali, and Zlatev, 2019; Kwon et al., 2020; Martinus et al., 2021; Sigler, Neal, and Martinus, 2023;

Subacchi, 2008; Xiang, Lin, and Wang, 2023). In SNA, a broker is commonly defined as an intermediary that occupies a crucial network position or, more technically, a “structural hole” (Burt, 2010) between other actors, whom it allows to interact by facilitating financial, material or knowledge exchange. At the level of the global political economy, brokers can be understood as managing relations among states, institutions, companies, and individuals by means of relational capital (Kale, Singh, and Perlmutter, 2000, p. 218), whereas they themselves often lack direct control over military resources or the capacity for state action. At the same time, brokers are not independent actors but usually belong to the institutional or economic spaces of one or more states - they are "state-centred" without necessarily being part of the formal state apparatus - or fall under the authority supranational bodies or multinational corporations. The degree to which brokers are subject to direct state or organizational control varies, however (Laruelle and Kevin Limonier, 2021). In fact, the very quality of an actor as a broker strongly depends on the context, in the sense that what appears as a broker in one concrete set of historical and spatial conditions may lose their broker quality in another set of conditions. The activities of brokers are often geographically dispersed, temporally limited, sector-specific, and typically exercised across borders (Subacchi, 2008).

2.1 Conceptual Propositions

Our understanding of brokerage is predicated on three complementary concepts, each of which focuses on a different aspect of the nexus between state strategies, networks, and the global political economy: 1) the networked structure of globalization, 2) adaptation as both a proactive, state-led strategy and a reactive process, and 3) brokers as managers of cross-border rent channelling. First, we depart from the assumption of a *networked global political economy*, an idea that can be found in economic theorizing since the 19th century, yet which has gained significant trajectory with the discourse on globalization and the transformative impact of cross-border information and resource flows since the 1990s (Kobrin, 1997). A host of scholars has since then recast globalization in network terms. Castells’s Network

Society thesis, to pick a widely discussed example, argued that new information-technology networks span the globe without boundaries, creating “a new spatial architecture” that links major cities into a single world-system (Castells, 2010). In a similar vein, Sassen posited a “new spatial order” under globalization, which would be organized by networks of global metropolises connected by digital infrastructures and flows of people, capital and culture (Sassen, 2013). Economists and geographers alike shifted to network-based models, showing that transnational webs of firms and suppliers – global production networks (GPNs) or global value chains (GVCs) – are the “critical organizational platforms” coordinating world production (Yeung and Coe, 2015). In short, from the mid-1990s onward the dominant accounts of globalization supplanted linear or hierarchical metaphors with an emphasis on interlocking networks of power, finance, information and culture.

Even as growth in global trade and investment has stalled in recent years, scholars continue to use network concepts to explain the contemporary landscape. Proponents of the network view note that globalization’s underlying web of ties remains in place – and indeed can be exploited for advantage – even amid protectionist backlashes. Farrell and Newman (2019) show that key global economic networks are highly asymmetric: major powers that jurisdictionally control central nodes (such as financial messaging or internet platforms) can “weaponize interdependence” by using their network position to gather intelligence (the “panopticon” effect) or to choke off rivals (the “chokepoint” effect, see also Fishman, 2025). Such analysis implies that the persistence of networked structures and their embedded power relations are precisely what makes globalization resilient and strategically important, even in a geoeconomic “slowbalization” era characterized by fragmentation. Likewise, scholars of economic geography have found that cross-border production networks continue to “constitute the long-term structural architecture of the global economy” (Yeung and Coe, 2015). Thus, whether globalization is waxing or waning, the network paradigm remains central for understanding how trade, finance and communication reconfigure. For it highlights the very patterns of both interconnection and strategic control that survive geopolitical tensions,

crises or efforts to de-globalize.

Such network thinking also illuminates how states, firms and societies adapt to external shocks and systemic change, as adaptation often occurs not through isolation but through reconfigured ties. In practice, sub-national and national actors frequently respond to global challenges (from economic crises, climate change to health pandemics) by forming new transnational networks that redirect or pool resources, share knowledge and foster new exchange patterns. In short, a networked lens shows adaptation as a multi-level, collaborative process, in which resilience derives not just from internal reforms (policies) but also from how effectively actors plug into wider webs of exchange and support (politics and relationships).

Second, we conceive of state strategies of adaptation as something that has both *reactive* and *proactive* components. Adaptation is usually defined as the social, economic, political and cultural adjustment to actual or expected changes in external processes, practices and structures, aimed at moderating potential damages or benefitting from opportunities associated with this change (*Introduction to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC)* 19.05.2025). State elites and corporate heads experience or anticipate actual or future changes in the external contexts in which they operate and craft formal and informal strategies to cope with this change. This process cannot be reduced to a functionalist reply but always includes "creative" and, therefore, non-derivable elements. In doing so, states depend on transnationally integrated intermediaries. In effect, ABNs allow a state elite to position themselves as central actors in a fragmented yet globalized economy, actively reworking transnational ties to shape outcomes. This is reflected in network models in International Political Economy (IPE), which “derive state capabilities and influence from the network structure” (Oatley et al., 2013, p. 137). The perspective that states gain power from how they are connected, therefore, foregrounds state-led initiatives (through policy, elite coalitions and business networks) as strategic levers in global systems.

Network-based adaptation often aims to preserve rents, regime stability, or continued ac-

cess under systemic change. For example, rentier Gulf monarchies have created or expanded sovereign wealth funds to centralize investment and stabilize patronage. Studies show these funds were introduced as “adaptive responses to external pressures” and as tools to sustain political authority under volatile conditions (Montambault Trudelle, 2023). China’s leadership likewise deploys state-centric networks, using intense state control of its financial institutions and the “internalization” of capital markets as “an adaptive strategy” securing its development model within global capitalism (Birley, 2023). In Russia’s case, the Kremlin has forged a parallel economy after 2022, re-routing trade and finance through rouble- and yuan-based mechanisms beyond Western reach (Quénelle, 04.03.2025; Nölke, 2025). Chinese exports now supply roughly 70 to 90 percent of key imported inputs to Russia (Ng and Ma, 17.05.2024), exemplifying how non-Western powers leverage global production and finance networks strategically to sustain core industries amidst external pressure. In each instance, ruling elites proactively rewire networks – pooling rents at home and securing vital links abroad – rather than simply reacting to external shocks. Thus even regimes without formal rule-making authority or capacity, such as Russia, can preserve rents by repositioning elites within global webs (Hoppe, 2026).

Third, we maintain that the operation of networks in a fragmenting world economy at the service of state elites is predicated on the existence of brokers, which denotes the access to, control of and distribution of resources via intermediate webs. Rather than the depersonalised, price-mediated process described in Liberal economic textbooks on globalization, or the coordinated economic coercion by a transnational capitalist class bemoaned by Marxists, networked brokerage is a highly political and conflictual endeavour. Classic network theory frames brokerage in terms of actors spanning gaps or “structural holes” between groups (Burt, 2010) and forming “weak ties” (Granovetter, 1973) that transmit novel information and allow resource exchange between otherwise separated actors.⁴ Burt’s sem-

4. Granovetter’s concept of weak ties highlights that casual acquaintances – not “close friends” – are often the most valuable conduits for new information and opportunities. In IPE, weak ties have become a core metaphor for understanding how states and global actors navigate fragmented global systems. Farrell and Newman’s framework of “weaponized interdependence” builds on this logic (2019): states that control central

inal work shows that such brokers gain strategic advantage by bridging disconnected actor clusters – controlling information flows and substituting isolated contacts with a connected network position. Actor–Network Theory (Latour, 2007) offers a complementary view by conceptualizing translation as an active process of enrolling and transforming actors, so that one actor or artifact may stand in for or substitute another within the network. Network closure (Coleman, 1988) then plays a shielding role: dense ties within a group build trust and shared norms that insulate insiders even as brokers connect to outsiders.

The sketched framework allows for the formulation of a set of conceptual propositions on the expectable dynamics of ABNs. First, when formal institutional ties break down due to economic sanctions or trade barriers, actors seek alternative pathways to maintain essential economic and political linkages. State-led networks respond strategically by activating and intensifying brokerage roles across different domains and spaces. Critically placed brokers are actively reconfiguring the network to sustain resource flows, thus demonstrating strategic adaptation. Second, actors with higher degrees of domestic political embeddedness exhibit greater agility in adapting to changing external contexts. Political elites, state-owned enterprises, or corporate actors closely connected to a "core network" of central political decision-makers or critical economic actors will exhibit higher strategic flexibility, since politically embedded actors enjoy superior access to information, legitimacy, and resources, allowing them to rapidly pivot across finance, sanctions, diplomacy, and climate governance spheres. Third, centralization within ABNs – where fewer intermediaries coordinate more connections – facilitates quicker and more efficient network-level responses to external disruptions, such as geopolitical shifts or regulatory shocks. For centralized networks can rapidly mobilize resources, disseminate information, and enforce new organizational routines through tightly coordinated brokerage.

nodes in global networks (like banking rails or internet infrastructure) can disrupt adversary access, while states outside these central circuits rely on weak ties – such as alternative legal channels, informal brokers, and non-Western partners – to maintain linkages and circumvent chokepoints. Likewise, literature on global value chains emphasizes that peripheral countries often build resilience by cultivating distant, low-density connections to multiple global hubs, rather than relying solely on deep ties with a single dominant partner – effectively using weak ties as a buffer against shocks.

2.2 Methodology

Applying network approaches to the case of post-Soviet Russia has been highly productive. Studies of what some characterize as the “Russian network state” (Moshes and Kononenko, 2011) include the analysis of patron-client networks as drivers of regime personalization (Baturro and Elkind, 2016; Leeson et al., 2024), the networked management of regional governance (Berg-Nordlie, Holm-Hansen, and Kropp, 2018) and the military-industrial complex (Shkurenko et al., 2025), personal networks as facilitators of state-building (Easter, 1996), intra-state elite networks (Kryschtanowskaja and White, 2011), networks as means of everyday informal exchange (Ledeneva, 1998; Michailova and Worm, 2003; Rose, 2000), patronage networks as foreign policy tools (Marten, 2013), networks as bottlenecks of financial regulation (Viktorov, 2015), networks of treaties in Russia’s regional policies (Willerton, Slobodchikoff, and Goertz, 2012), and BRICS as a networked geopolitical structure (Жданов, 2013). However, while conceptually innovative and empirically rich, almost all of these studies remain limited to the domestic level, excluding cross-border networks from their analysis.

This paper, in contrast, focuses on a critical, information-rich yet scholarly unexplored ego-network: We single out Kirill Dmitriev who, since 2011, has served as CEO of the Russian Direct Investment Fund (RDIF) and, in 2025, was appointed Special Presidential Envoy on Foreign Investment and Economic Cooperation by Putin. His wife Natalia Popova has served as a deputy on the board of the Innopraktika Foundation, a Russian NGO headed by Putin’s daughter Katerina Tikhonova. Dmitriev, who was born in Ukraine, has been operating at the service of Russian state power across various arenas. His fields of activity range from global finance and state-led development, sanctions evasion, climate and environmental, social and governance (ESG) initiatives, and multipolar diplomacy, making him an ideal gateway through which to observe how networks and elite brokerage help Russia adapt to various dimensions of global change. The RDIF, in turn, is of particular interest here, because existing scholarship has identified sovereign wealth funds (SWFs) as major state-led vehicles for adapting to the macro-structural processes of globalisation and financialisation

(Haberly, 2011). Sociological research on the management and practices of non-Western SWFs, in particular, suggests that these funds are deeply permeated by personalist logics and cannot be grasped by an aggregate analysis of investment flows alone (Montambault Trudelle, 2023). Therefore, focusing on one particular individual actor (Dmitriev) in charge of a state-related economic institutional vehicle (RDIF) and constructing an ego-network around it keeps the empirical reconstruction tractable while maximizing theoretical leverage. If ABN mechanisms are visible around a well-documented broker, they are likely to be present in other realms of Russia’s political economy and in comparative constellations in other countries.

Following the work of Lamberova and Sonin (2018), our methodological strategy employs large-scale, text-based extraction to map connections among elites, firms, and organization. We started with a qualitatively curated and hand-coded seed list of relevant actors, which includes a functionally diverse group of roughly 200 individuals, companies, and institutions linked to Kirill Dmitriev. The seed list was compiled by collecting and analysing English- and Russian-language media material, investigative reports, and secondary academic literature, and mostly serves to cross-check whether the computed entities involve the most relevant actors. The empirical foundation for our quantitative network analysis, in turn, is a large-scale corpus of Russian-language media coverage derived from the INTEGRUM database, one of the most comprehensive archives of Russian and post-Soviet news content. Using the search query “Кирилл Дмитриев,” we compiled a dataset containing more than 40,000 unique articles published between 2010 and 2025, which referred to Dmitriev. This period covers the entirety of Dmitriev’s public career, from his initial appearance in elite political-economic circles to his role in the post-2022 wartime environment. The dataset captures reporting from a wide variety of outlets, ranging from business and financial media to state-affiliated and independent political news sources. As INTEGRUM aggregates cross-sectoral content from thousands of sources across Russia and the wider post-Soviet region, it enables a broad reconstruction of the information environment in which Dmitriev’s brokerage activities

are documented.

To extract potential network actors from this corpus, we applied a named entity recognition (NER) pipeline in Python to identify mentions of individuals, firms, organizations, and institutions. The output of the NER was supplemented with an occurrence score indicating the number of articles in which each entity appeared. In order to focus on relevant actors and reduce noise, countries were excluded from the NER output and duplicates merged, and a threshold of 50 occurrences was set as the minimum for inclusion in the node list. This reduced the candidate list to a more manageable size, after which another manual cleaning process removed remaining false positives, irrelevant names, and duplicates. The result was a refined set of approximately 1,000 nodes (out of more than 18,000 initially identified entities), each representing an actor connected to Dmitriev’s network through media-documented positive and negative interactions. We then manually added four further attributes for each of the 1,000 actors: the specific type of actor, their location, the sector in which they are active, and whether they are a state or private actor.

We then performed an automated co-occurrence analysis. Usually, co-occurrence networks are reconstructed on the basis of media, legal, or even leaked sources and taken as a proxy for underlying social or transactional relationships. Existing studies (2023) and Mahdavi (2019) strongly suggest that even in opaque or authoritarian settings, elite networks can be mapped by triangulating public co-mentions, shared events, and indirect ties revealed in the digital record. Such a strategy is of particular use in Russia, where formal institutional data is often lacking, and where informal networks play a crucial, if concealed, role in adaptation and resilience. To reconstruct Dmitriev’s cross-border networks, we matched the refined and attributed node list of about 1,000 entities against the INTEGRUM media article corpus to detect instances in which two nodes were mentioned in the same article. To capture temporal variation in the structure of Dmitriev’s network, the dataset was sliced into four analytically distinct periods: pre-Crimea (2010–2013), post-Crimea sanctions consolidation (2014–2020), the COVID period (2020–2022), and wartime adaptation (2022–2025).

From the co-occurrence networks, we computed standard network metrics, including degree centrality, betweenness centrality, and weighted edge counts, to quantify patterns of connectivity and brokerage. We also conducted a Louvain community detection, a widely used mathematical algorithm for identifying densely connected subgroups within large networks. Technically, the Louvain algorithm partitions the network into communities by maximizing modularity, a measure of how well a given division captures intra-community cohesion relative to inter-community ties. This approach allows us to detect clusters of actors that function as semi-autonomous substructures within the broader adaptation brokerage network. Tracking the formation, dissolution, or reconfiguration of these communities over time provides insight into how Dmitriev’s brokerage position has been embedded in, and responsive to, shifting contexts. This approach enabled us to identify a stable domestic core network centred on the Dmitriev-RDIF nexus, alongside shifting international networks that aligned with geopolitical junctures and specific missions assigned "from above".

Our strategy carries with it all the unavoidable pitfalls and biases of Russian-language media material. Most media outlets scandalize (e.g., Trump’s Ukraine diplomacy) and dramatize (e.g., the international race for a COVID vaccine). In addition, smaller media outlets tend to adopt the reports of larger agencies. With regard to Russia in particular, many of the media outlets included in the study are close to the state or fully state-controlled, meaning that developments favourable to the Kremlin are emphasized, while negative ones are suppressed. All this means that both the extracted nodes and the reconstructed edges are a proxy of the actual network (dynamics) of Dmitriev and the RDIF, as seen through the eyes of the Russia’s autocratically structured public. As a result, as much as some critical connections may be under-represented due to constraints in source accessibility, some connections are significantly inflated and overrepresented due to commercially based media biases. However, through our qualitative, manual, and detailed cleaning, further attributional enrichment, and regular cross-checking of the computed network data with our qualitative seed list, we have sought to transform the reconstructed networks from a potential to an *actual*

one. A more general methodological challenge for the paper arises from increasing data opacity in the Russian context after 2022, particularly in the wake of heightened wartime secrecy, censorship and restricted media environments. This means that for many recent or evolving relationships, the available information is fragmentary, indirect, or absent altogether and cannot (yet) be mirror-checked by investigative reports. As Limonier and Audinet (2022) rightly caution, these problems constitute a substantial methodological challenge for the digital turn in the social sciences. Issues such as source and media bias, platform instability, and the deluge of unstructured data require balancing the speed and scale of computational techniques with rigorous, transparent and qualitative data curation and cleaning protocols, all of which we sought to secure during the analysis.

3 Cross-Temporal Network Structure, 2010-2025

Across the 2010–2025 period, the Dmitriev network displays both remarkable adaptability and a persistent underlying architecture. Even as Western sanctions related to Russia’s annexation of the Ukrainian peninsula Crimea, disruptions caused by the global COVID-19 pandemic, or the trade, diplomatic and military repercussions of the full-scale invasion of Ukraine reshaped the structure and scope of Russia’s international engagement, the internal composition of the network remained strikingly consistent. The resulting general spatial and compositional architecture of the network is schematically depicted in Figure 1, with a tightly connected domestic core surrounded by persistent domestic nodes and more fluid international partners. The result is a pattern of relative domestic network resilience, wherein domestic stability provides the basis for flexible and selected outward adaptation. Taking a more disaggregated perspective, the data shows that the network’s dense core is anchored primarily in executive authority and state-linked economic institutions, with figures such as Putin and Dmitry Medvedev embedded alongside key financial entities that serve as organisational hubs. These include Russia’s main state-owned development bank Vnesheconombank,

the largest financial institute Sberbank, and the two oil and gas majors Gazprom, and Rosneft, as well as financial and spatial coordinating bodies such as the Ministry of Finance (MinFin) and the Federation Council (the upper house of the Federal Assembly, representing Russia's federal subjects). Additional nodes such as the Central Bank of Russia (CBR), VTB (a major Russian bank specialized in foreign trade), and regulatory and coercive institutions (e.g., the Federal Antimonopoly Service, the Prosecutor General's Office, and the Federal Security Service) reinforce this core, creating a highly interconnected state-capital nexus that persists across each of the four analyzed periods.

Further zooming in, the cross-temporal network structure can be analytically decomposed into a small number of functionally differentiated clusters centred on distinct roles within Russia's hierarchized and layered rent-distributing political economy. At the core of the network stands what can be called a *patronal executive cluster* (e.g., Putin, Medvedev, Igor Shuvalov, Sergei Lavrov), which is closely intertwined with a *financial-allocative core* (Vnesheconombank, Sberbank, VTB, CBR, MinFin) that channels and redistributes rents "on political request" and provides the financial backing for Dmitriev's international "missions". This is complemented by *strategic state corporations* (Gazprom, Rosneft, Russian Railways, Rostec) that both generate (through exports or domestic infrastructural and technological monopolies) and appropriate (through trade, fees and taxes) these rents, and, finally, a *regulatory-coercive apparatus* (Federation Council, State Duma, Federal Anti-Monopoly Service, Prosecutor General's Office, but also security agencies such as the FSB) that stabilises and enforces the system legally, procedurally and often coercively. Surrounding these network layers is a more fluid set of *external interface nodes* (e.g., UN General Assembly, IMF, BRICS, Donald Trump), with whom Dmitriev has interacted internationally and which are selectively activated for situational brokerage without becoming structurally embedded in the network in a sustained way.

Notably, the flexibility of these external interface nodes contrasts sharply with the network's domestic backbone, the latter of which seems not contingent on specific events but

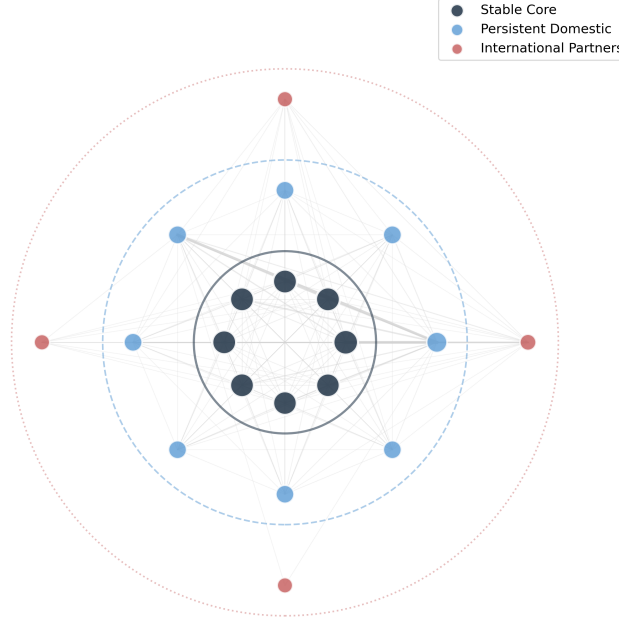


Figure 1: Stylized Network Scheme

anchored in rather enduring personal and institutional relationships. Many of the persistent domestic institutions do not necessarily dominate in terms of visibility or frequency, but their structural positions (often combining, in technical terms, moderate degree with relatively high closeness) suggest a critical role in maintaining systemic integration across otherwise segmented institutional fields. In this sense, the network is highly hierarchical and, most importantly, dominated by a clear patronal executive cluster yet, at the same time, also exhibits a layered architecture in which coordination is distributed across multiple state interfaces headed by sub-patrons loyal to Putin. A more fluid component of the network consists of major corporate and infrastructural actors that operate at the intersection of domestic governance and external economic engagement. Firms such as Russian Railways, Rostelecom, Lukoil, and MegaFon, alongside platforms like the Moscow Exchange, function as intermediaries that translate state priorities into operational activities on both domestic and global markets. The centrality indices of these actors vary more over time than those of core political actors, indicating a slightly higher degree of functional repositioning in response to shifting economic and geopolitical contexts. Nevertheless, their recurrent presence

in the top 50 network actor scores across the four analyzed periods (see Tables 1, 2, 4, and 5) underscores the extent to which brokerage is embedded in a surprisingly stable domestic organisational infrastructure steered by a rather small personalist network at its core.

With respect to our argument of organizational repurposing, the outer layer of the network is most interesting. It is selectively permeable, in the sense that it is composed of international actors and organisations whose presence is episodic but structurally meaningful in Russia's foreign policy and engagement with different global actors. Figures such as Trump and Volodymyr Zelenskyy, as well as platforms including the UN General Assembly, BRICS, NATO, and the IMF, enter the network in ways that are highly uneven across time yet consistently associated with moments of intensified external engagement. These actors almost never attain the same degree of embeddedness as domestic nodes (therefore supporting Granovetter's notion of the "strength of weak ties", if in a temporally limited way), but their appearance reflects Dmitriev's brokerage role connecting otherwise weakly linked domestic and international network clusters. The overall pattern suggests that the Dmitriev operates from a deeply entrenched domestic core and is able to establish event-sensitive external interfaces, in which international linkages are activated, reconfigured, or attenuated without fundamentally altering the underlying network structure.

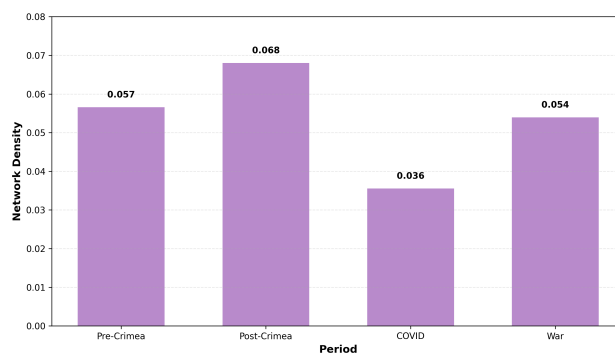


Figure 2: Network Density, 2010-2025

Further data analysis reinforces this interpretation. In particular, we find that external shocks lead to selective densification instead of destabilizing disintegration. However, this network densification (see Figure 2) does not follow a linear trajectory; instead, it increases

markedly in the aftermath of disrupting sanctions, most notably following 2014 and again after 2022. This suggests a process of sanction-induced relational compression, in which previously more loosely connected actors are drawn into tighter, mostly domestic patterns of intensifying coordination and interaction. Interestingly, the decline in density during the COVID period appears only as a temporary loosening, but the subsequent increase under wartime conditions indicates a more durable shift toward adaptive closure.

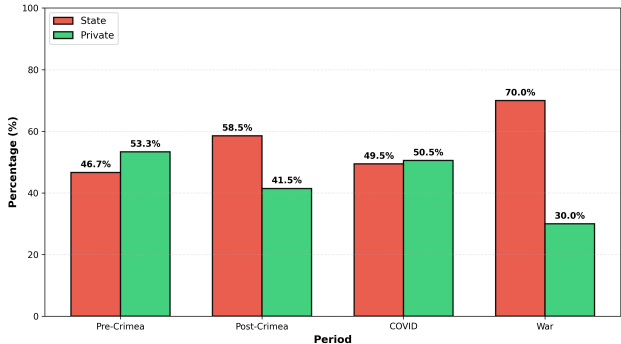


Figure 3: Network Statization, 2010-2025

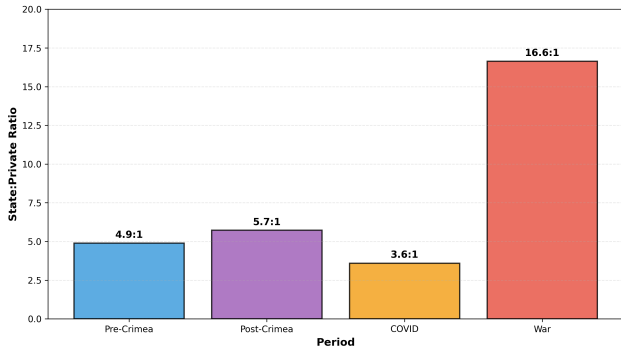


Figure 4: Ratio between State and Private Actors, 2010-2025

We further find that the composition of the network shifts systematically toward a more pronounced state dominance over time (see Figure 3). While the pre-Crimea period exhibits a relatively balanced mix of state and private actors, in line with the initial mission statement of the RDIF, subsequent periods show a steady increase in the weight of state-linked nodes. This trend is particularly pronounced since Russia’s 2022 assault on Ukraine and the establishment of unprecedented sanctions against the Russian economy. The state-to-private

ratio rises sharply and state actors account for a clear majority of the network (see Figure 4). This evidence points toward a pattern beyond a mere quantitative change of outgoing and incoming nodes. Instead, the network pattern has changed qualitatively, in the sense that private actors have become increasingly marginal and instead appear more tightly embedded within state-centred coordination structures. The temporary and modest private rebalancing during the COVID period, when selected private actors were mobilized to develop the Sputnik-V vaccine, could apparently not reverse this overarching trajectory.

Taken together, these dynamics point to a marked tension at the heart of the network’s evolution. Initially oriented toward attracting private investment and facilitating diversification of Russia’s political economy, the network becomes progressively statized and internally consolidated under conditions of sustained external pressure. Over time, Dmitriev’s brokerage through the RDIF has become increasingly concentrated within state-aligned actors and institutions. The result is a form of modular stability, in which the network retains coherence and responsiveness while gradually narrowing its functional scope. In this sense, the same mechanisms that underpin network resilience — densification and elite continuity — also contribute to the erosion of the network’s original developmental ambition.

4 Network Evolution and Organizational Repurposing

Despite a stable tripartite network structure (see Figure 1), composed of a patronal-executive core, domestic (financial-allocative, strategic-corporative and regulatory-coercive) auxiliary networks, and an adaptive external interface, our evidence also suggest that Dmitriev’s network adapts markedly in response to major geopolitical, economic shocks and global crises by regularly shifting its international purpose and absorbing newly emerging actors while excluding others. Along the four sliced periods, it is this external interface, in particular, that expands, contracts, reorients and, therefore, is at the core of Dmitriev’s global brokerage on behalf of the Russian state. Taking the network’s shifting global interface as a compara-

tive axis, the remainder of this section distinguishes and describes four repurposed network constellations - developmental expansion, spatio-economic diversification, health-industrial crisis management, and wartime rehabilitation - each of which entailing a different brokerage pattern and interacting international actors (see Table 3).

4.1 2010-2013: Developmental Expansion and Embedded Global Integration

The years preceding Russia’s annexation of Crimea in 2014 marked Dmitriev’s emergence in Russian business and economic policy-making circles and his appointment as the globally connected new director of the RDIF. Our evidence from this period reveals a network that is both structurally anchored in Russia’s state–capital nexus and (in retrospective) remarkably open to international integration. At its core, the configuration is organised tightly around executive authority in persona of Putin and Medvedev (who both served as presidents and prime ministers during those years and had considered the creation of a Russian SWF a top priority), as well dense financial and developmental clusters. What distinguishes this early phase, however, is the extent to which this domestic backbone is complemented by a structurally embedded international layer. Actors such as the International Monetary Fund (IMF), the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development (EBRD), the World Trade Organization (WTO), and major Western financial institutions are well integrated into the network’s upper tiers. In contrast to later periods, this produces a relatively balanced configuration in which Dmitriev and the RDIF operate through outward-oriented financial intermediation, linking Russian state actors and strategic resource and infrastructural companies (e.g., Gazprom, Russian Railways, Lukoil) to global capital markets (e.g., Deutsche Bank, Goldman Sachs, London Stock Exchange) and multilateral institutions. In this sense, the pre-Crimea network clearly reflects a phase of developmental expansion, in which the RDIF functions as a platform for attracting investment and embedding Russia within international financial markets.

The ranking of central actors in Table 1 underscores this pattern. Rather than being dominated exclusively by political authority, the network’s upper tier is populated by financial and technocratic nodes that mediate between state power and global markets. Alongside the governmental actors, institutions such as VEB, Sberbank, VTB, and the CBR occupy highly central positions, while international actors, including the EBRD, IMF, and even Deutsche Bank, appear prominently within the same structural space. This pattern suggests that Dmitriev’s brokerage in the pre-Crimea period is not primarily personalistic but strongly institutionally mediated, with development banks, global finance, and market interaction carrying a substantial share of network connectivity. Private and hybrid economic actors (e.g., the telecommunication firms MTS and MegaFon, with which the RDIF had projects) also featured prominently in the network, suggesting that in the pre-Crimea period, there was a relatively permeable boundary between state and private economic actors (see the pre-Crimea columns in Figure 3, where private outnumber state actors). A Louvain community analysis underscore these findings. It reveals only loose community boundaries and an absence of distinct community polarization at this early stage of the network, with clusters blending together rather than separating into distinctive blocs.

A closer look at the sectoral composition of the nodes reveals how the relative outward-orientation of the network at the time was primarily anchored in export-oriented industries, infrastructure, and communications (e.g., through Gazprom Neft, Lukoil, Rostelecom, and Russian Railways). At the same time, participation in multilateral and regional platforms, including APEC, the WTO, BRICS, and the Customs Union (as the predecessor of the Eurasian Economic Union), indicates that Dmitriev’s inaugural RDIF network extended well into institutionalised arenas of international coordination, where economic and diplomatic linkages could be formalised and scaled. What emerges in these early years, therefore, is a relatively evenly balanced and functionally integrated network, in which sectoral, institutional, and regulatory components collectively sustain an expansive ABN. The pre-2014 composition thus provides a critical baseline, capturing a moment in time at which Russia’s

Table 1: Top 50 Actors by Composite Score, 2010-2014

Rank	Actor	Composite	Degree	Closeness	Occurrences	Edge Count
1	Vladimir Putin	0.6204	0.4222	0.6289	8641304	12467
2	Vnesheconombank (VEB)	0.5745	0.4864	0.6555	5087945	18482
3	Sberbank	0.4649	0.4397	0.6359	1498992	12282
4	Dmitry Medvedev	0.4540	0.4105	0.6250	1720576	12318
5	Moscow Exchange	0.4520	0.3969	0.6189	1974478	12100
6	Ministry of Finance	0.4453	0.4241	0.6281	1055116	11845
7	Russian Railways	0.4307	0.3949	0.6167	1126356	10990
8	State Duma	0.4113	0.4047	0.6160	133472	8748
9	Federation Council	0.4057	0.3755	0.6064	559440	8910
10	Gazprom	0.3999	0.3677	0.6050	467562	8789
11	Russian Academy of Sciences	0.3738	0.3346	0.5889	187131	7346
12	Ministry of Culture	0.3573	0.3093	0.5815	40950	6174
13	International Monetary Fund (IMF)	0.3548	0.2918	0.5802	259522	7001
14	Rostelecom	0.3526	0.2588	0.5698	914498	6307
15	Supreme Arbitration Court	0.3453	0.2879	0.5743	14798	5719
16	MTS	0.3449	0.2121	0.5544	1657044	5076
17	Ministry of Internal Affairs	0.3448	0.2802	0.5743	131207	6071
18	Prosecutor General's Office	0.3374	0.2724	0.5673	64264	5809
19	Civic Chamber	0.3374	0.2724	0.5679	52955	5076
20	Federal Antimonopoly Service	0.3362	0.2607	0.5648	258125	5135
21	VTB Bank	0.3330	0.2315	0.5556	785600	6206
22	Alexei Ulyukayev	0.3330	0.2412	0.5592	552160	6325
23	MegaFon	0.3302	0.2451	0.5604	343680	5167
24	Alexei Navalny	0.3269	0.2549	0.5604	32200	5141
25	Lukoil	0.3218	0.2393	0.5586	112252	5178
26	Chamber of Commerce and Industry	0.3206	0.2412	0.5520	145130	5528
27	German Gref	0.3205	0.2296	0.5580	236082	4962
28	Accounts Chamber	0.3166	0.2335	0.5550	53757	4128
29	Federal Tax Service	0.3142	0.2276	0.5562	30186	3948
30	Central Bank of Russia	0.3140	0.2160	0.5550	243840	4402
31	Igor Shuvalov	0.3114	0.1907	0.5437	764556	5276
32	National Wealth Fund	0.3086	0.1848	0.5386	830028	5669
33	Deutsche Bank	0.3061	0.2101	0.5496	95996	6114
34	Sergei Lavrov	0.3025	0.1907	0.5449	359522	3413
35	World Trade Organization (WTO)	0.3001	0.1965	0.5490	83600	3917
36	Sergei Sobyenin	0.3001	0.2004	0.5449	84624	4017
37	Investigative Committee of Russia	0.2992	0.2004	0.5455	35711	3841
38	United Russia	0.2981	0.1965	0.5466	38100	3760
39	UN General Assembly	0.2970	0.1907	0.5391	221464	3771
40	Rusal	0.2963	0.1965	0.5414	48636	3641
41	European Bank for Reconstruction and Development	0.2960	0.1770	0.5414	370689	4811
42	Presidential Human Rights Council	0.2949	0.1946	0.5420	12397	3625
43	Federal Reserve (Fed)	0.2919	0.1887	0.5403	14442	3505
44	Angela Merkel	0.2910	0.1809	0.5431	57512	3564
45	NATO	0.2908	0.1790	0.5420	104232	3314
46	Ministry of Digital Development	0.2888	0.1770	0.5408	72732	3148
47	Moscow City Court	0.2885	0.1809	0.5386	30530	3393
48	Arkady Dvorkovich	0.2882	0.1673	0.5313	378756	4670
49	Sergei Shoigu	0.2867	0.1751	0.5403	24400	2930
50	Nicolás Maduro	0.2851	0.1770	0.5352	9555	3182

ABNs and the country's political economy more broadly still operated through extension into permissive global markets rather than through the contraction and selective closure that would characterise subsequent phases.

4.2 2014-2020: Spatio-Economic Diversification and Selective Re-orientation

From 2014 onwards, following Russia's annexation of Crimea, Dmitriev's RDIF network enters a phase of adaptation under a modest wave of Western individual and economic sanctions. Most interestingly, our data shows that these sanctions did not dismantle existing structures but triggered an overall spatial and economic diversification, alongside a domestic consolidation and selective reorientation of the network's global interface (see also 2). While ties to European financial and institutional actors understandably weaken or disappear, new connections emerge with BRICS economies, Gulf sovereign funds, and Chinese partners, as well as, more selectively, with US-based actors. This shift depicts, on the one hand, a geographical diversification that resulted from the decision to sanction-proof the Russian economy. On the other hand, the shift reflects a change in the logic of Dmitriev's brokerage, as his international engagement becomes more politically sensitive for his interlocutors and, therefore, become more mediated and strategically targeted. The growing prominence of actors such as Saudi Aramco, alongside platforms like APEC, the SCO and, not least, the newly established Eurasian Economic Union, points to the increasing importance of resource-linked and non-Western multilateral channels of international engagement. It also indicates the difficulty to diversify economic activities away from the resource sector under conditions of sanctions. At the same time, the post-Crimea data shows that some factions of foreign capital remain on active terms with Russia, but their overall engagement becomes more selective and niche. The appearance of Donald Trump in the data indicates Dmitriev's first turn toward personalised political brokerage as a complementary diplomatic strategy engaging informally with the Trump I cabinet.

Notwithstanding the external repurposing, the ranking of central actors during this period (see Table 2) reveals a network that remains structurally anchored in its financial-institutional core, but whose functional orientation has shifted. However, compared to the pre-Crimea period, the network exhibits a clear thickening of the state layer, with bodies such as the Federation Council, State Duma, Federal Antimonopoly Service, and security-related institutions (e.g., Investigative Committee, Ministry of Internal Affairs, National Security Council) occupying more central and interconnected positions. Moreover, strategic state corporations such as Gazprom, Rosneft, Russian Railways, Rostelecom, and Rosseti become even more tightly integrated with the patronal-executive core, functioning as tightly managed, key operational nodes for redirecting trade, investment, and infrastructure linkages under sanctions and geopolitical rupture with the West. (Semi-)Private actors (e.g., MTS, MegaFon, VimpelCom), linked to the RDIF via investment projects, remain visible but appear more deeply embedded within state-coordinated structures, indicating a gradual erosion of their autonomy.

The looming statization is also reflected in an increasing ratio between state to private actors (see Figures 4 and 3), indicating that adaptation increasingly operates through formal and coercive state structures rather than through relatively open financial intermediation. At the same time, however, while international state and transnational network actors (e.g., UN General Assembly, IMF, European Commission, Barack Obama, Recep Tayyip Erdoğan) remain present, they are significantly less structurally embedded, reflecting a transition toward a pattern of more selective and politically filtered forms of brokered engagement.

Table 2: Top 50 Actors by Composite Score, 2014-2020

Rank	Actor	Composite	Degree	Closeness	Occurrences	Edge Count
1	Vladimir Putin	0.7008	0.5605	0.6916	13601728	23563
2	Federation Council	0.4996	0.5366	0.6803	873600	20456
3	Vnesheconombank (VEB)	0.4980	0.4583	0.6456	3837665	17292
4	Gazprom	0.4772	0.4974	0.6625	899037	18009
5	Russian Railways	0.4663	0.4651	0.6485	1417962	15195
6	Dmitry Medvedev	0.4491	0.4276	0.6344	1654224	13683
7	Rosneft	0.4417	0.4242	0.6316	1313744	15943
8	Ministry of Finance	0.4381	0.4276	0.6323	961651	14160
9	Sberbank	0.4259	0.3901	0.6182	1536400	12976
10	Moscow Exchange	0.4257	0.3969	0.6202	1282754	13359
11	Federal Antimonopoly Service	0.4169	0.4020	0.6229	470525	12375
12	UN General Assembly	0.4091	0.3884	0.6169	470611	11108
13	State Duma	0.4046	0.3884	0.6163	185072	11545
14	VTB Bank	0.3965	0.3492	0.6042	1031100	11357
15	Civic Chamber	0.3948	0.3731	0.6105	92115	11936
16	Investigative Committee of Russia	0.3907	0.3663	0.6067	107133	12170
17	Ministry of Internal Affairs	0.3784	0.3407	0.5998	150998	9300
18	Prosecutor General's Office	0.3728	0.3322	0.5961	101936	9859
19	Sergei Lavrov	0.3727	0.3118	0.5889	845145	8739
20	Sergei Naryshkin	0.3603	0.3083	0.5871	145034	7914
21	Ministry of Digital Development	0.3585	0.3049	0.5853	162052	8307
22	Central Bank of Russia	0.3428	0.2709	0.5761	274320	6844
23	International Monetary Fund (IMF)	0.3426	0.2760	0.5716	244256	6420
24	Alexei Ulyukayev	0.3423	0.2572	0.5705	762120	8762
25	MTS	0.3422	0.2436	0.5655	1263888	6250
26	Ministry of Culture	0.3417	0.2794	0.5733	42575	7038
27	Igor Shuvalov	0.3403	0.2521	0.5677	841464	8331
28	Rostelecom	0.3402	0.2385	0.5638	1311746	8882
29	Moscow City Court	0.3376	0.2692	0.5733	43665	6506
30	Arkady Dvorkovich	0.3373	0.2555	0.5699	487473	6915
31	National Security Council	0.3370	0.2675	0.5710	110528	6406
32	Barack Obama	0.3355	0.2641	0.5705	113046	6479
33	BRICS	0.3312	0.2334	0.5627	869888	6369
34	MegaFon	0.3303	0.2487	0.5666	283536	6427
35	Presidential Human Rights Council	0.3254	0.2470	0.5655	27830	5916
36	Central Bank	0.3217	0.2351	0.5638	141459	5724
37	Sergei Sobyenin	0.3209	0.2368	0.5622	87904	5699
38	Anton Siluanov	0.3209	0.2334	0.5563	340554	5860
39	National Wealth Fund	0.3198	0.2147	0.5495	962580	6905
40	Federal Assembly	0.3179	0.2300	0.5617	85383	5305
41	European Commission	0.3114	0.2164	0.5579	115434	4788
42	Rosseti	0.3101	0.2129	0.5558	176673	5269
43	Rosstat	0.3091	0.2147	0.5563	51870	5074
44	VimpelCom	0.3082	0.2095	0.5531	213210	4774
45	Andrei Kostin	0.3076	0.2061	0.5479	404156	6862
46	Ministry of Emergency Situations	0.3055	0.2095	0.5526	44599	4501
47	Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO)	0.3052	0.2078	0.5526	68970	5071
48	Central Bank	0.3039	0.2095	0.5485	49815	4567
49	Accounts Chamber	0.3013	0.1993	0.5516	65160	4274
50	Recep Tayyip Erdoğan	0.3006	0.1993	0.5500	61686	4550

Table 3: Change of Global Interface Modes and Dmitriev's Brokerage Patterns Across Periods. Own Compilation. Note: Examples listed in the column "International Nodes" are drawn from the Top 50 non-Russian actors computed by composite score for each respective period.

Period	Overall Network Dynamic	Global Interface Mode	Brokerage Pattern	Key International Nodes
Pre-Crimea (2010–2013)	Developmental Expansion	Embedded Global Integration	Institutionalised SWF participation in the global economy and multilateral governance	IMF; EBRD; APEC; WTO; Deutsche Bank; Goldman Sachs; London Stock Exchange; China Investment Corporation
Post-Crimea (2014–2019)	Spatio-Economic Diversification	Selective Reorientation	Sanctions adaptation through partial substitution and politically filtered diversification	UN General Assembly; RCIF; BRICS; SCO; APEC; Xi Jinping; Erdoğan; EAEU/EEC; DP World
COVID (2020–2021)	Health-Industrial Crisis Management	Issue-Specific Layering	Pandemic-era engagement organised around health diplomacy, while older geopolitical and economic channels remain in the background	WHO; UN General Assembly; Research Capital Investment Fund (UK); Saudi Aramco; BRICS; EMA; Oxford University; Public Investment Fund (SAU); China Investment Corporation; OPEC+
War (2022–2025)	Wartime Rehabilitation	Personalised (Para-)Diplomacy	Fragmented, event-driven, and conflict-structured engagement through high-level political and informal channels	Steven Witkoff; Volodymyr Zelenskyy; Marco Rubio; Mike Waltz; NATO; BRICS; Xi Jinping; Joe Biden; Emmanuel Macron; Erdoğan; Elon Musk

4.3 2020-2022: Health-Industrial Crisis Management and Issue-Specific Layering

The COVID-19 period (2020–2022) represents a very stark case of broker-mediated repurposing along a very domain-specific axis, as vaccine-developing industrial policy and health diplomacy become the central channel of engagement. Most notably, the crisis management of the pandemic triggered a layering of new actors (both private and state-related) and functions onto an otherwise stable state-centred architecture. Dmitriev managed to reposition the RDIF as a key intermediary in the development, financing, and international promotion of the Sputnik V vaccine, mobilising a hitherto little connected ensemble of scientific, industrial, and diplomatic actors. Institutions such as the Russian Gamaleya Research Centre and the World Health Organization enter the network as highly central nodes, reflecting the emergence of a health–scientific cluster that is absent in earlier periods.

Table 4 reflects a network that has kept its stable core but has been repurposed towards a new technoscientific function, embodied by high centrality scores for the Gamelaya Institute and the WHO. They integrate into existing structures and are operated through them, with financial institutions and state bodies facilitating the scaling and international projection of Dmitriev’s vaccine-related initiatives and health diplomacy. Compared to the post-Crimea period, international linkages appear less geopolitically reoriented and more issue-bound, tied specifically to the global management of the pandemic.

At the same time, the broader constellation of international actors (see the nodes indicated in Table 3) points to a process of layered expansion, in which the emerging health diplomacy interface is grafted onto pre-existing geopolitical and financial ties. Alongside the WHO and the UN General Assembly, the IMF, OPEC+, and BRICS remain strongly embedded. Crucially important for Dmitriev’s later wartime value for Putin, the simultaneous prominence of political figures such as Joe Biden, Emmanuel Macron, and Xi Jinping suggests that Dmitriev’s brokerage expanded beyond mere economic coordination into high-level political communication and negotiation.

Table 4: Top 50 Actors by Composite Score, 2020-2022

Rank	Actor	Composite	Degree	Closeness	Occurrences	Edge Count
1	Vladimir Putin	0.6642	0.4965	0.6639	27843228	28827
2	Sberbank	0.4081	0.3551	0.6064	3270528	17251
3	Gamaleya National Research Centre for Epidemiology and Microbiology	0.3969	0.1581	0.5377	16512960	17301
4	Donald Trump	0.3824	0.2788	0.5810	5364072	11869
5	Russian Railways	0.3652	0.2940	0.5848	1901004	12461
6	Ministry of Finance	0.3635	0.2954	0.5852	1570212	11792
7	VTB Bank	0.3574	0.2857	0.5819	1445504	10916
8	World Health Organization (WHO)	0.3568	0.2164	0.5585	6524658	13722
9	Federation Council	0.3502	0.2802	0.5796	871920	10238
10	Federal Antimonopoly Service	0.3490	0.2732	0.5777	1197700	10634
11	Dmitry Medvedev	0.3455	0.2621	0.5750	1482624	9485
12	Vnesheconombank (VEB)	0.3452	0.2552	0.5691	2160206	9510
13	UN General Assembly	0.3268	0.2358	0.5655	869829	8013
14	Rosneft	0.3247	0.2288	0.5628	1119827	9628
15	Mikhail Mishustin	0.3157	0.2191	0.5580	677344	8879
16	Alexander Novak	0.3142	0.2094	0.5516	1362922	10074
17	Yandex	0.3128	0.2136	0.5593	505556	8201
18	Volodymyr Zelenskyy	0.3055	0.1983	0.5529	699888	7201
19	International Monetary Fund (IMF)	0.3019	0.1969	0.5533	250542	5955
20	German Gref	0.3012	0.1928	0.5512	503426	7903
21	Maksim Oreshkin	0.3007	0.1928	0.5491	541762	8562
22	Central Bank of Russia	0.2963	0.1845	0.5504	328168	5963
23	Anton Siluanov	0.2953	0.1789	0.5446	825432	7797
24	Gazprom	0.2932	0.1748	0.5462	671532	6238
25	Dmitry Peskov	0.2928	0.1595	0.5401	1806993	5712
26	Investigative Committee of Russia	0.2871	0.1706	0.5450	119925	5648
27	Accounts Chamber	0.2862	0.1678	0.5450	152040	5238
28	Moscow Exchange	0.2858	0.1581	0.5385	1004751	5406
29	Oleg Deripaska	0.2854	0.1678	0.5417	226269	5690
30	Federal Security Service (FSB)	0.2853	0.1664	0.5437	165264	5827
31	Sergei Lavrov	0.2811	0.1484	0.5357	1041004	4692
32	Arkady Dvorkovich	0.2808	0.1581	0.5357	459417	5831
33	OPEC+	0.2771	0.1359	0.5349	1221321	5762
34	Sistema	0.2769	0.1387	0.5353	1019125	6927
35	Lukoil	0.2766	0.1498	0.5365	287804	5172
36	Central Bank	0.2749	0.1456	0.5385	180882	4181
37	Rostec	0.2747	0.1429	0.5377	341032	4406
38	National Security Council	0.2744	0.1456	0.5377	152064	4203
39	Ministry of Internal Affairs	0.2740	0.1442	0.5381	151731	4449
40	Prosecutor General's Office	0.2718	0.1429	0.5349	95288	4140
41	Russian Academy of Sciences	0.2707	0.1359	0.5337	404985	4312
42	Russia-China Investment Fund	0.2702	0.1082	0.5221	2513368	6340
43	Novatek	0.2699	0.1373	0.5325	280469	5332
44	Andrei Belousov	0.2687	0.1359	0.5298	341066	5380
45	Sibur Holding	0.2678	0.1304	0.5278	630480	5197
46	Alrosa	0.2676	0.1318	0.5305	378378	5386
47	Ministry of Energy	0.2675	0.1318	0.5317	287655	4087
48	Michael Calvey	0.2669	0.1262	0.5301	609070	9238
49	Andrei Kostin	0.2651	0.1290	0.5274	350198	4808
50	State Duma	0.2648	0.1276	0.5325	108016	3365

Taken together, the COVID-period network can be best understood as an instance of issue-specific adaptation, in the sense that the network temporarily expanded into the rather narrow and hitherto untouched domain of health diplomacy, thereby reinforcing Dmitriev’s role as a flexible broker capable of redirecting existing relational infrastructures toward emergent opportunities.

4.4 2022-2025: Wartime Rehabilitation and Personalised (Para-)Diplomacy

The period following Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 marks the most pronounced transformation of Dmitriev’s network, characterised by hyper-centralisation, intensified statization (see Figure 3), and the collapse of structured international integration. Under conditions of unprecedented Western sanctions and exclusion from global financial circuits, the network undergoes a process of internal consolidation and what must be called functional compression. As co-investments with Russian actors are seen as potential triggers of secondary sanctions, Dmitriev’s brokerage shifts decisively away from the classical territory of investment attraction, toward political and diplomatic mediation ordered from above. Put differently, Dmitriev and the RDIF are repurposed as instruments of wartime coordination and high-level opportunistic deal-making (Hoppe, 2026). While the network becomes more inward-oriented and tightly interconnected, reflecting the concentration of elite resources within a constrained environment, external engagement is heavily narrowed toward a set of selective and often highly personalised channels. These interactions include both non-Western partners and institutions as well as informal interlocutors in the West.

The structure of central actors in Table 5 reflects this shift toward politicised and personalised brokerage. Unsurprisingly, executive figures dominate the upper ranks, closely followed by a dense cluster of political intermediaries, including, among others, Russia’s foreign minister Sergei Lavrov and special aide Yuri Ushakov. Strikingly, international political actors - such as Trump, Steven Witkoff, Marco Rubio, and other US-linked figures — ap-

pear prominently as nodes in informal, leader-driven channels of engagement. This marks a decisive departure from earlier periods in which financial and organisational intermediaries structured external relations. Domestic financial institutions, the RDIF's initial core network, remain present but are clearly subordinated to political priorities, functioning as instruments of wartime stabilisation rather than as vehicles of developmental expansion and outward integration. Strategic corporations remain tightly integrated into this core yet now have turned into instruments in sustaining resource flows, energy diplomacy, and industrial coordination under conditions of war and sanctions.

A defining feature of the wartime network is the integration of adversarial actors and the heightened visibility of security and monitoring institutions, which fundamentally alters the network's external interface in comparison to earlier periods. Actors such as Zelenskyy, the Ukrainian Armed Forces, and NATO appear as highly connected nodes, not as partners, of course, but as structuring antagonists. At the same time, domestic institutions such as the National Security Council, Rosfinmonitoring, and Rospotrebnadzor gain prominence, indicating the expansion of surveillance, control, and regulatory capacities within the network. The international layer now clearly lacks the coherence of the pre-war period and instead reflects a fragmented, event-driven, and markedly opportunistic pattern of engagement, combining adversarial, symbolic, and selectively cooperative ties.

Taken together, the wartime network must be understood as the preliminary endpoint of a longer trajectory toward state-centred consolidation and the (geo)politicisation of brokerage. The functional differentiation present in the RDIF's inaugural years is reduced, as financial, industrial, and regulatory actors have become increasingly subordinated to a unified yet much narrower political logic centred on wartime adaptation. (Semi-)Private recede into the background, while remaining nodes are drawn more tightly into clusters organised around patronal-executive authority and state coordination. Brokerage persists and is all the more important to negotiate Russia's rehabilitation, but it has almost completely moved onto personalized-diplomatic terrain.

Table 5: Top 50 Actors by Composite Score, 2022-2025

Rank	Actor	Composite	Degree	Closeness	Occurrences	Edge Count
1	Vladimir Putin	0.7093	0.5778	0.6954	26002788	23212
2	Donald Trump	0.5523	0.4254	0.6262	17110464	23926
3	Steven Witkoff	0.4846	0.3333	0.5855	15225595	27762
4	Volodymyr Zelenskyy	0.4356	0.4095	0.6117	3530685	18378
5	Sergei Lavrov	0.4318	0.3778	0.6069	4925988	16999
6	Yuri Ushakov	0.4228	0.3556	0.5989	5335440	17912
7	Dmitry Peskov	0.3710	0.2889	0.5769	3202756	10321
8	Marco Rubio	0.3434	0.2286	0.5488	4222829	17437
9	VTB Bank	0.3255	0.2413	0.5635	469396	3337
10	Ministry of Finance	0.3212	0.2349	0.5556	650101	3276
11	Sberbank	0.3099	0.2127	0.5497	643952	3093
12	Federation Council	0.3045	0.2063	0.5459	467040	2956
13	Elvira Nabiullina	0.3044	0.2095	0.5488	139776	2988
14	Rosatom	0.3040	0.2127	0.5431	221877	3718
15	Alexander Novak	0.2958	0.1968	0.5348	409481	2987
16	UN General Assembly	0.2958	0.1905	0.5385	547832	3529
17	Mikhail Mishustin	0.2920	0.1873	0.5385	216672	2394
18	Maksim Oreshkin	0.2912	0.1905	0.5348	140231	2635
19	NATO	0.2893	0.1778	0.5330	653256	6239
20	Gazprom	0.2850	0.1714	0.5339	368715	2412
21	Vnesheconombank (VEB)	0.2842	0.1683	0.5294	670289	2448
22	Mike Waltz	0.2838	0.1492	0.5250	1840086	11923
23	National Security Council	0.2827	0.1683	0.5348	192896	2813
24	Russian Railways	0.2824	0.1683	0.5303	387324	2194
25	Denis Manturov	0.2807	0.1683	0.5303	165888	2268
26	Alexei Likhachev	0.2804	0.1714	0.5285	55778	2771
27	Igor Shuvalov	0.2802	0.1683	0.5276	242788	2512
28	Central Bank	0.2791	0.1619	0.5330	149189	1933
29	BRICS	0.2790	0.1492	0.5321	846102	2336
30	Anton Siluanov	0.2761	0.1619	0.5241	216486	2374
31	Dmitry Chernyshenko	0.2730	0.1556	0.5259	52644	1967
32	Xi Jinping	0.2712	0.1460	0.5294	129682	1692
33	German Gref	0.2709	0.1524	0.5215	171402	1990
34	Maksim Reshetnikov	0.2700	0.1524	0.5215	53120	2061
35	Rosneft	0.2695	0.1460	0.5233	230604	1839
36	Elon Musk	0.2675	0.1302	0.5224	836404	4234
37	Andrei Belousov	0.2669	0.1397	0.5250	129890	1786
38	Andrei Kostin	0.2653	0.1397	0.5207	144946	1946
39	Joe Biden	0.2650	0.1302	0.5198	649740	4548
40	Emmanuel Macron	0.2604	0.1270	0.5189	264457	3885
41	Igor Sechin	0.2562	0.1238	0.5155	53463	1472
42	Ukrainian Armed Forces	0.2551	0.1175	0.5181	110802	2987
43	Oleg Belozеров	0.2545	0.1206	0.5147	43706	1342
44	Alexei Miller	0.2526	0.1175	0.5130	47433	1448
45	Dmitry Shugaev	0.2484	0.1111	0.5097	5828	1135
46	Novatek	0.2482	0.1079	0.5114	64890	1203
47	Russian Union of Industrialists and Entrepreneurs	0.2481	0.1016	0.5147	209934	1349
48	Rospotrebnadzor	0.2470	0.1048	0.5114	76095	985
49	Rosfinmonitoring	0.2469	0.1016	0.5155	5400	898
50	Moscow Exchange	0.2463	0.0952	0.5122	426855	1308

5 Conclusion

This paper’s network approach and the reconstructed patterns of adaptation, brokerage, and global interface agility provide distinct and empirically supported insights into Russia’s adaptive capacity, which supplement other, more common approaches. The evolution and structure of Dmitriev’s network indicate that despite suffering serious blowbacks due to Western sanctions, Russia’s engagement with the global political, economic and diplomatic-institutional order has been remarkably resilient. Our findings demonstrate that the simultaneous dual domestic embeddedness in a patronal and executive core and financial-institutional clusters has helped Dmitriev and the RDIF to adapt to changing external contexts. We conclude that the combination of adaptive, mission-driven interface flexibility, steered by one of Putin’s close sub-patrons, and institutional anchorage is central to understanding the resilient global engagement of Russia under external constraints. We further contend that the combination of personalist flexibility with organizational resources, stability and symbolical backing - without the need to legitimize policies and decisions to broader social constituencies - should be understood as a distinct authoritarian advantage in manoeuvring a restructuring global order.

Our finding of this sociologically stabilizing mechanism adds to policy-oriented explanations, which would attribute Russia’s adaptive response to institutional reforms or creative state policies enacted in the wake of crises. While such measures are undoubtedly relevant, our network reconstruction suggest that adaptation is enacted through flexible, informal relationships that cut across institutional boundaries, regulatory frameworks or inter-corporate cooperation, enabling rapid and creative responses that rigid ("rules-based") hierarchies may be ill-equipped to provide. Our network analysis thus reveals hitherto under-explored forms of authoritarian adaptive capacity and flexibility that would remain invisible if attention were restricted to formal institutional changes and policies alone.

The findings also diverge from resource- and capability-based explanations, which posit that actors with the most material resources or technical expertise are best positioned to

adapt. The paper demonstrated, in contrast, that informal political embeddedness undergirds external agility. This implies that access, influence, and connectivity within the political elite may be more decisive for adaptive success than mere possession of resources or technological advantages. This rather counter-intuitive claim opens up a novel productive comparative perspective on modes of networked adaptation both among autocracies as well as across democratic and authoritarian regimes.

On a more general note, this paper has sought to render plausible the theoretical claim that cross-border ABNs are under-recognized pillars of resilient authoritarian engagement on a global scale under conditions of geopolitical rupture. They allow states a degree of organizational flexibility amidst domestic contradictions and a messy process of global restructuring on multiple levels – even authoritarian, extractivist or dependent states such as Russia that are usually assumed to preside over rather inflexible political economies. Our study thus allows to hypothesize that a hitherto underexplored part of the story of global fragmentation is to be found in the relational infrastructures that let elites, resources and information pass through and operate through networks across the many crises of our time. In the Russian case, this infrastructure is, above all, inextricably interwoven with the personalistic fabric of Russian statehood, which has demonstrated a surprising flexibility and adaptability under the pressures of political contestation, sanctions, resource market volatility, and even war. This is not to argue in favour of the supposed sustainability and functionality of the Russian growth model. Anno 2026, the country’s political economy is highly unbalanced, subject to serious physical shortcomings, and in need of non-conventional sources of finance. However, the implication of our analysis is that the ability of the Russian state elite to navigate the many unpredictabilities of the present by means of personalism, ABNs, and organizational repurposing should not be underestimated. This holds all the more true in a world that is witnessing a return of personalist rule at the cost of depersonalised state structures (Hanson and Kopstein, 2022), opening manifold global interfaces for Russia’s ABNs across the globe.

Future research may advance our line of inquiry into two directions. For one thing,

the finding of the patronal repurposing of institutions needs to be combined with a more disaggregated breakdown and comparative reintegration of sector-specific brokers and mechanisms of Russian ABNs. This will allow to gain a more causal understanding of the nexus between network adaptability and actual sectoral performance in Russia. On the other hand, a more comparable research design might allow to synthesize the conceptual ABN framework and the SNA methodology into a typological theory that can be used to explore ABNs in other cases of authoritarianism under external pressure, such as Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps' businesses, the United Arab Emirates' climate-finance brokerage, Venezuela's oil intermediaries, or North Korea's shadow traders. Ultimately, this will contribute to understanding how otherwise constrained autocracies stay adapt in a fragmenting and geopoliticizing global order.

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